

FREE PROMPT PACK

NYC Through *Time*: the prompts

Every prompt I used to put myself into 143 years of New York history, from the Brooklyn Bridge opening in 1883 to the streets of SoHo today. Copy, paste, swap in your own details.

BY WOMEN LEAD AI · WOMENLEAD.AI

BEFORE YOU START

You don't need to be a *filmmaker*

You've seen those AI videos where someone walks through history and thought, I could never make that. Here's the truth: it's four steps, and most of the work is writing clear prompts. I've done that part for you.

In my video I visit seven moments in New York: 1883, 1904, 1917, 1930, 1931, 1964 and 2026. I'm dressed for each decade, the year flips past on an old paper calendar, and every clip comes with its own music and sound. You can copy the whole thing, or pick your own city and your own moments.

WHAT YOU NEED

- **A Higgsfield account.** My finished video used about 550 credits at 1080p: seven 6 second clips at about 72 credits each, plus a few credits per image.
- **6 to 8 photos of you.** Clear face, different angles, natural light, no heavy filters. A full length shot helps.
- **A list of your moments.** Real events with real dates. Check each one before you build a scene around it.
- **A video editor** such as CapCut, to add the calendar and stitch the clips.

Each video clip takes about 5 to 7 minutes to render, so start one, then write the next prompt while you wait.

THE FOUR STEPS

1. **Dress for every era:** one character sheet per decade.
2. **Set the scene:** one start frame per moment.
3. **Bring it to life:** animate each frame into a 6 second clip with sound.
4. **Flip the calendar:** add the years in your editor and stitch it all together.

Go to Higgsfield here: higgsfield.ai

STEP 1

Dress for *every era*

A character sheet locks your face and outfit so you look the same in every shot. Make one per decade. In Higgsfield go to **Images**, pick **GPT Image 2.5**, quality high, aspect ratio 16:9, and upload all your photos as references.

```
Photorealistic character reference sheet of the exact real woman shown in all the
reference photos. Preserve her identity precisely: same face shape, nose, eyes, lips,
jaw, eyebrows, skin and age as in the photos. Do not beautify, age up or alter her
features. [HAIR COLOUR], [EYE COLOUR], [SKIN], [LIPS], [EARRINGS].

Outfit ([CITY], [YEAR], historically accurate [ERA] outfit): [HAIRSTYLE FOR THE ERA];
[HAT]; [TOP OR BODICE]; [SKIRT, DRESS OR TROUSERS]; [GLOVES, BAG, SHOES].

Layout: three views side by side on a clean white seamless studio background with soft
even natural light. Left: full body head to toe facing camera, relaxed elegant pose.
Center: full body head to toe back view. Right: head-and-shoulders 3/4 portrait with a
slight relaxed smile. Real unretouched photo look, natural skin texture, real fabric. No
text, no labels, no logos.
```



Do this: keep the words "do not beautify". Generate a couple and keep the one that looks most like you. Everything after this depends on it.

STEP 1

My outfit lines, *ready to paste*

Drop one of these into the Outfit line of the prompt above.

ERA	OUTFIT LINE
1883	New York, May 1883, historically accurate early 1880s day dress: hair pinned up in a soft period chignon with a light fringe; a small dark plum straw hat tilted forward with a cream silk ribbon and a small feather; a fitted deep plum silk taffeta bodice with a high cream lace collar, long fitted sleeves and a row of small brass buttons; a long draped plum and cream overskirt with a modest bustle; cream kid gloves; a closed cream lace parasol; black leather button boots.
1904	New York, October 1904, historically accurate Edwardian autumn walking outfit: hair in a soft full Gibson girl pompadour; a wide-brimmed dark navy felt hat trimmed with a cream silk ribbon and deep red silk roses; a white high-neck lace shirtwaist blouse; a fitted dark navy wool jacket, cropped at the waist, with leg-of-mutton sleeves; a long dark navy gored walking skirt; brown leather gloves; a small brown leather handbag on a chain.
1917	New York, 1917, historically accurate suffragist marching outfit: hair in a soft low loose bun; a wide-brimmed white straw hat with a plain golden yellow ribbon band; an all-white cotton lawn and lace dress, long sleeves, ankle length; a wide plain golden yellow satin sash worn diagonally, blank with no lettering; white cotton gloves; white lace-up ankle boots; a small plain golden yellow pennant flag.
1930s	New York, 1930 to 1931, historically accurate early 1930s day look: hair in soft sculpted finger waves; a small deep emerald green felt hat tilted to one side; a bias-cut deep emerald green crepe day dress with a small white collar and narrow belt; a short cropped black wool jacket with padded shoulders; seamed stockings; black T-bar heels; a black clutch bag.
1964	New York, spring 1964, historically accurate mod look: a voluminous bouffant with flipped ends and a wide white headband; winged eyeliner and pale pink lipstick; a sleeveless tangerine orange and white colour-block A-line shift dress, just above the knee; a short white boxy cropped jacket with big round buttons; white go-go boots; round white sunglasses; a small structured white handbag.
Today	Present day, 2026 New York: long camel wool coat worn open, cream fine knit crew-neck jumper, straight leg mid-blue jeans, white leather trainers, a small black leather shoulder bag.

Tip: give each era its own colour (plum, navy, white and gold, emerald, orange). Viewers clock the jump in time before they read the year.

STEP 2

Set the *scene*

Now make one still image per moment: you, in that era's outfit, in that place. This is your start frame. Same model, **GPT Image 2.5**, quality high, **9:16**. References: the era's character sheet first, then two clear photos of your face.

```
Photorealistic vertical 9:16 cinematic film still. ONLY the main woman has the face from Reference Images 2 and 3; do not beautify her. She wears exactly the outfit from the character sheet (Reference Image 1): [PASTE YOUR OUTFIT LINE].

[CITY], [EXACT DATE], [THE MOMENT]. She stands in the [LEFT / RIGHT] half of the frame, [POSE AND EXPRESSION]. [DESCRIBE THE PLACE: architecture, objects, light]. Around her [THE CROWD], each a clearly different person of different ages and backgrounds. [LIGHT AND COLOUR MOOD], soft film grain. Shot on ARRI Alexa with an anamorphic lens, shallow depth of field, natural skin texture, real fabric. Historically accurate. No modern objects, no readable text, no signs with words, no watermark.
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MY 1904 EXAMPLE

New York, 27 October 1904, opening day of the first underground subway line, City Hall station. She stands on the curved platform, three quarter view, looking along the platform with excited anticipation. The station: elegant curved vaulted ceiling of cream and green Guastavino tiles in herringbone patterns, brass chandeliers glowing, leaded glass skylights letting in soft daylight. Around her an excited crowd in 1904 dress: men in bowler hats and long overcoats, women in wide hats and long skirts, a newsboy in a flat cap. In the background the headlight of an early 1900s subway train approaches round the curve. Warm amber light.

Check before you animate: does anyone in the crowd have your face? If they do, regenerate. Fixing a still costs a few credits. Fixing a video costs 72.

STEP 3

Bring it *to life*

Go to **Videos** and pick **Seedance 2.5**. Settings: reference mode, 1080p, 9:16, 6 seconds, audio on. Start image: your start frame. References: the era's character sheet plus two photos of your face. If Higgsfield suggests a preset, decline it and generate your prompt as written.

```
⚠️ CHARACTER REFERENCE – MANDATORY: ONLY the woman in the [OUTFIT COLOUR] has the face from the real photos: [HAIR, EYES, SKIN, LIPS]. Outfit from the character sheet, unchanged: [OUTFIT LINE].
⚠️ CRITICAL – EVERYONE ELSE IS A DIFFERENT PERSON. NON-NEGOTIABLE: every other person keeps exactly their own distinct face from the start image. Nobody else resembles her. No duplicated faces.
⚠️ CRITICAL – ANATOMY. NON-NEGOTIABLE: Proportions consistent every frame. Joints bend naturally. Every step lands, no gliding. Hands have five fingers. No morphing faces.
⚠️ CRITICAL – REALISM. NON-NEGOTIABLE: Real Hollywood period film. Shot on ARRI Alexa 65, anamorphic lens, [GRADE FOR THE ERA], soft film grain. Real fabric physics. Historically accurate [YEAR] [CITY]. Indistinguishable from real footage.
⚠️ CRITICAL – CAMERA. NON-NEGOTIABLE: ONE continuous shot, 9:16 vertical. Never cuts. Keep her in the [LEFT / RIGHT] half of the frame.

SETTING: [THE MOMENT AND PLACE].

0–2 sec: [WHAT SHE DOES, WHAT THE CROWD DOES, CAMERA MOVE].
2–4 sec: [THE BIG ACTION].
4–6 sec: she turns to the lens with a [EXPRESSION] smile. [FINAL CAMERA MOVE]. Still moving on the final frame.

⚠️ AUDIO – MUSIC AND SFX: [PERIOD MUSIC, e.g. 1880s brass band, ragtime piano, 1930s big band, 1964 surf guitar]; [SOUND EFFECTS OF THE PLACE]. No dialogue, no lyrics.

No readable text, no letters, no numbers, no watermark, no captions, no modern objects.
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STEP 3

My 1917 clip, *word for word*



SETTING: a women's suffrage march on Fifth Avenue, autumn 1917, blank golden yellow and white banners and American flags, crowds on the pavements, golden autumn leaves drifting down.

0–2 sec: she marches forward with purpose, chin up, the varied column of women marching behind her. Camera tracks backward in front of her at walking pace.
2–4 sec: she raises her yellow pennant high and waves it; spectators on the pavement cheer and wave hats and handkerchiefs; the older woman behind her smiles.
4–6 sec: she turns her face to the lens with a proud, radiant smile, still marching. Camera slowly rises a little to show the long column on the avenue. Still moving on the final frame.

AUDIO: a rousing marching brass band and snare drums, rhythmic footsteps of many marchers, a cheering crowd, applause, flags flapping in the wind, leaves rustling. No dialogue, no lyrics, no chanting words.

MUSIC FOR EACH ERA

1883	a lively brass band march, cheering, steamboat whistles
1904	ragtime piano, train rumble, iron brakes, a conductor's bell
1917	marching band and snare drums, footsteps, a cheering crowd
1930s	swinging big band brass, rivet guns, old car horns, wind
1964	twangy surf guitar, organ and handclaps, fountains, a camera shutter
Today	uplifting piano and strings, taxi horns, a distant siren

STEP 4

Flip the *calendar*



The calendar isn't made by the AI. AI video often garbles numbers, so add the years yourself in the edit. That way every date is exact.

1. Make an old paper tear-off calendar page for each year: yellowed paper, a brick red strip at the top, the year in an old-style serif.
2. Over the first second of each clip, flip quickly through the years in between, slow down, and land on the new year.
3. Once it lands, slide in the name of the moment underneath in an old script font, for example "The First Subway Ride".
4. Put it on whichever side is clear of your face. That changes from clip to clip.
5. Add a soft paper flick sound to every page.
6. Stitch the clips in date order with short crossfades and keep each clip's own sound.

Shortcut: I asked Claude Code to build the calendar flip for me as an overlay video, then dropped it on top of each clip. If you use Claude, describe the look above and ask for "a transparent overlay video I can put on top of my clip".

MY MOMENTS

1883	The Brooklyn Bridge opens (24 May 1883)
1904	The first subway ride, City Hall station (27 October 1904)
1917	Women win the vote in New York (6 November 1917)
1930	The Empire State Building rises
1931	The Empire State Building opens (1 May 1931)
1964	The World's Fair comes to Queens (opened 22 April 1964)
2026	New York today

LEARN FROM MY REDOS

Five fixes that *saved my clips*

1. **Everyone had my face.** In my first suffrage march, every woman looked like me. Creepy. Say "only the main woman has the face from the references" and describe the crowd as clearly different people: ages, backgrounds, hair, clothes.
2. **I wasn't looking at the building.** If your eyes matter, say exactly where they go: "her eyes stay fixed up on the building, to the upper right, she never looks away". Then check the still before you animate.
3. **I loved the last two seconds, not the first four.** Grab the frame you like, upload it as a new start image, and generate again from there.
4. **History has its own rules.** Check every date and detail. The famous photo of workers eating lunch on a beam was taken at the RCA Building in 1932, not the Empire State.
5. **One moment per clip.** Six seconds is enough for one idea: one place, one action, one look to camera.

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